



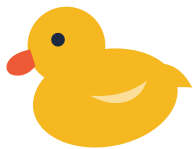
Play Before Pixels

Printable • Ages 1–5

74 busy book activities

Toddler Busy Book

Matching, sorting, colors, shapes, pretend play, first words and mazes, sorted by age, with a “talk while you play” line on every page.



duck



red



● 1–2 years

● 2–3 years

● 3–5 years

49 no-cut pages • 0-minute prep

What's in your download

Five files. Open this one first, then print from the file that matches your paper. Page numbers in this guide point to the main book.

1	START HERE.pdf	This guide: quick start, grown-up guide, safety, assembly, printing and quick answers.
2	Color • US Letter	All 132 pages in color, 8.5 × 11 in.
3	Color • A4	All 132 pages in color, 210 × 297 mm.
4	Low-ink • US Letter	White pages with colorable line art. Same pages, same piece sizes.
5	Low-ink • A4	White pages with colorable line art, A4.

Type-in pages

In every main file, the binder covers, spine and pouch labels, make-your-own pages, weekly planners and certificate have type-in boxes. Open the file in a free PDF reader, type, save, then print.

Prep time

0 minutes for 49 pages. **5–10 minutes** for pages with pieces (straight cuts only, 12 pieces or fewer per sheet).

Play today in four steps

Prep time: **0 minutes** for 49 pages (print and play). **5–10 minutes** for pages with pieces: straight cuts only, 12 pieces or fewer per sheet. No page takes longer to prep than it plays.

1 Find your child's age band

Pages are sorted by age. Ages are starting points, not deadlines: move up or down whenever you like.

● **1–2 years • pages 19–45**

● **2–3 years • pages 46–78**

● **3–5 years • pages 79–118**

2 Print one no-cut page and play

Good first pages: **1–2**: “ball” (p.21), Who says “moo”? (p.25), Peekaboo house (p.40) · **2–3**: Color hunt in the park (p.53), Beep beep! Drive to the park (p.76), One, two, three (p.73) · **3–5**: Help Duck get to the pond (p.80), Blast off to the moon (p.105), Which one is different? (p.97).

3 Cut pieces when you have ten minutes

Each piece sheet sits right after its activity page. Cut on the straight dashed lines, count the pieces into a pouch, and the grown-up keeps the pouch. Laminating and velcro are optional (tips on page 9).

4 Talk while you play

Every page has one line to say out loud. That line is the heart of the book. Read the 2-page grown-up guide next (pages 4–5).

74

activities in 3 age bands

49

no-cut pages, ready
today

23

piece sheets • 157 pieces,
all 2 in or bigger

132

pages in all, US Letter
and A4

Inside too: binder covers in 4 colors, spine and pouch labels, a weekly busy-book planner (Monday and Sunday starts, pre-filled and blank), make-your-own pages you can type into, a Busy Book Star certificate, an answer key and quick answers. **Color and Low-ink files** are included: Low-ink prints on white with colorable line art.

What you need today

- A printer and plain paper or cardstock
- A grown-up and a child, side by side
- That's it for the 49 no-cut pages

Nice to have later

- Scissors or a paper trimmer (straight cuts only)
- Sheet protectors or a laminator, a binder and zip pouches
- Velcro dots, for the 3–5 pages only

Why busy-book play?

Little ones learn words from the people who talk and play with them. A busy book gives the two of you something to point at, name and move around, so the talk comes easily. You don't need a plan or a script; the pages give you one.

2-minute setup

1. Print one page. Cutting can wait.
2. Sit side by side or with your child on your lap.
3. Let your child touch, point and choose first.
4. Say the "talk while you play" line, then pause.
5. Stop while it's still fun. Short is perfect.

Most children love 2–3 of these

You don't need all 74. Most children find two or three favorites and want them again and again. That's not boring for them: repeating is how play grows. Rotate a few pages each week and keep the rest for later.

Three talk lines that work on any page

SAY WHAT YOU SEE

"Big red apple!"

Name what your child is looking at, in a few words.

PAUSE AND WAIT

"Ready, set... (wait)"

Count to five in your head. Give your child room to take a turn.

ADD ONE WORD

"Duck." → "Yellow duck!"

Repeat what your child says and add one word.

Every turn counts

Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. A sign, a point, a look, a sound or a device tap all count as a turn. There's no right answer on any page: if your child calls the frog a "duck," say "A green frog! Ribbit!" and keep playing.

Every way of playing counts

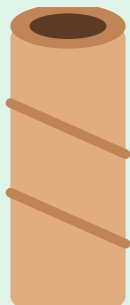
Lining pieces up, playing the same page again and again, moving around, humming, or playing side by side instead of face to face: it's all play. Eye contact is never needed. If your child says no or walks away, stop and try another day.

Big kids can help

Brothers, sisters and cousins about 6 and up make great helpers: they can read the talk line out loud, run the café or deliver the mail. A grown-up stays right there and keeps the pieces.

Our play safety rules

Every page in this book follows these rules. Please read them once before you start.



The toilet-paper-tube test

For children under 3, nothing small enough to fit through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm across). **Every cut piece in this book is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger** on its shortest side, and the pieces for 1–2 years are 2.5 in (6.4 cm) or bigger.

Grown-up keeps the pieces

Count pieces out and back in. Store them in a pouch or envelope that the grown-up keeps. Throw away any piece that tears, bends, gets wet or peels.

Always together

Every activity is played with a grown-up right there. Read together and keep paper and pieces away from mouths.

Velcro rules

No loose velcro dots for under-3s: for 1–2 and 2–3 pages, lay pieces on top. For 3–5 pages velcro is optional: **check dots before each play** and keep pieces away from younger children.

Laminated edges

Leave a small border when you cut laminated pieces and round the corners so edges stay soft.

Crayons and pens

Dry-erase crayons are for the 3–5 pages, with a grown-up. The grown-up keeps caps, which are small.

Pretend food only

The food pages are pictures. No real food is part of any activity, and none of the pictured foods are small, hard or round snacks.

Nothing else to add

No balloons, beads, buttons, coins, strings or cords are used or needed anywhere in this book.

Real toys? A few pages suggest a real toy (a ball, a toy car, a box). For under-3s, any real toy must pass the tube test and have no small parts that come off. If you're ever unsure, leave it out: the page works without it.

Grown-up tools. Scissors, the paper trimmer and the laminator (it gets hot) are for grown-ups. Plastic zip pouches, sheet protectors and laminating scraps stay out of reach: plastic isn't a toy.

Build your busy book three ways

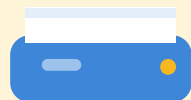
Pick the one that fits your week. You can start with the quick one today and upgrade later.



Quick: no laminator

1. Print pages on cardstock (or plain paper).
2. Slide each page into a clear sheet protector.
3. Keep pages in a 1–1.5 in 3-ring binder.
4. Pieces go in a zip pouch clipped to the binder.

About 15 minutes for 10 pages.



Classic: laminated

1. Print on cardstock and laminate (3–5 mil pouches).
2. Cut pieces with a small clear border; round corners.
3. Punch holes and use binder rings or a binder.
4. One labeled pouch per piece sheet.

Pieces last for months of play.



Velcro: ages 3–5 only

1. Laminate first, then add dots.
2. Soft (loop) dot on the page, scratchy (hook) dot on the piece.
3. Press firmly; let dots set overnight.
4. Check dots before each play.

No velcro for under-3s.

Use only for the 3–5 pages.

Handy supplies

- Cardstock, 65–110 lb (176–300 gsm)
- Scissors or a paper trimmer (straight cuts only)
- Sheet protectors or a laminator (optional)
- Binder or binder rings, and zip pouches
- Velcro dots for the 3–5 pages (optional)

Organize by age

Use one binder cover per child or per age band (4 colors on pages 13–16). Tape a pouch label to each pouch (page 18). Keep 5–8 pages in the binder and rotate the rest each week with the planner on page 124.

Print only what you need

Pick your file

- **US Letter** (8.5 × 11 in) or **A4** (210 × 297 mm): same pages, same piece sizes.
- **Color** for bright pages. **Low-ink** for white pages with colorable line art.
- The make-your-own pages can be typed into in a free PDF reader before printing.

Printer settings

- Print at **100% / actual size**. “Fit to page” shrinks pieces.
- Single-sided only: pieces and pages need blank backs.
- Print a page range (for example 19–27) instead of the whole book.

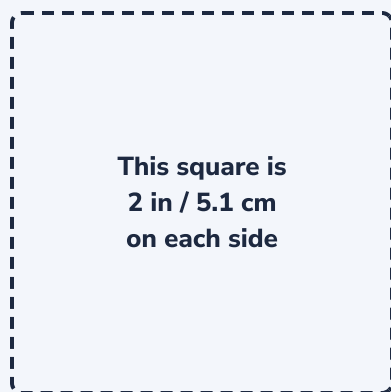
Paper

Cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) for pieces and anything you’ll handle a lot. Plain paper is fine for no-cut pages in sheet protectors.

Home or print shop

Home printers are perfect. For a sturdy set, a local print shop can print on cardstock and laminate; take the file on a USB stick and ask for “actual size.”

Check your size



**This square is
2 in / 5.1 cm
on each side**

Measure this square after printing. If it's smaller than 2 in (5.1 cm), your printer is scaling the page: choose 100% or actual size and print again. The pieces rely on it.

Questions, answered

What ages is it for?

About 12 months to 5 years, in three bands (1–2, 2–3, 3–5). Every page shows its starting age in months. Move up or down freely.

Do I have to cut everything?

No. 49 activities need no cutting at all. Cut piece sheets when you have ten minutes; each has straight cuts only and 12 pieces or fewer.

Are the pieces safe for my toddler?

Every piece is 2 in (5.1 cm) or bigger, bigger than a toilet-paper tube. A grown-up plays along, keeps the pieces and checks them each time. No velcro dots for under-3s.

Which file should I print?

US Letter or A4 to match your paper. Color for bright pages; Low-ink for white pages with colorable line art. Print at 100% / actual size.

Can I type into the pages?

Yes: the make-your-own pages, binder covers, labels, planner and certificate have type-in boxes that work in free PDF readers. Type, save, then print.

Do I need a laminator?

No. Sheet protectors or plain cardstock work well. Laminating just makes pieces last longer (tips on page 9).

Is anything shipped?

No, it's a digital download. You print at home or at a print shop, as many copies as your own family needs.

My child only wants one page. Is that OK?

Completely. Most children love two or three pages and repeat them. Try that page's "harder" line when it feels easy.

Is this a lesson plan or a program?

No. It's play for families: pages to talk about together, with no tests or scores. It isn't medical or professional advice. Questions about development go to your pediatrician.

Can I use it with a group or class?

This copy is for your own home. For a child-care, classroom or library license, send us a message through the shop.

Can I share it with a friend?

Please share a photo of your busy book, not the files. If a friend would like a copy, they can buy their own; it keeps new pages coming.

Is it only in English?

The printed words are in English. Say every word, talk line and rhyme in the language you know best; any language works. Type your family's own words on the make-your-own pages (p.120–121).

Can I give it as a gift?

Yes. Print it, slip the pages into a binder with a cover in their favorite color and give it ready to play. Please give the printed book, not the files.

A file won't open on my phone

Etsy downloads work best in a web browser on a computer or tablet (the app can't download files). Send us a message through the shop if you're stuck.